GPSC CBRT · HOMOEOPATHIC PHYSICIAN · CORE

# Topic 3: Homoeopathic Pharmacy

Complete notes with pictures, memory hooks, rapid revision and practice MCQs.

# Topic 3: Homoeopathic Pharmacy

## How to use this guide

Pharmacy is one of the ten Core topics (the Core section carries 25 of the 60 CBRT marks), so expect about 2 to 3 questions. They ask a ratio, a percentage, a licence form, a year or an abbreviation, so this guide keeps the numbers in tables you can learn cold.

| Syllabus heading | What it covers | Section |
|---|---|---|
| Sources, vehicles and drug collection | Vegetable, mineral, animal, nosodes, sarcodes, imponderabilia; liquid and solid vehicles | 3.1 |
| Scales and potentisation | Decimal, centesimal, LM; Hahnemannian and Korsakovian methods; trituration and succussion | 3.2 |
| Standards and legislation | Homoeopathic Pharmacopoeia of India; Drugs and Cosmetics Act and Rules | 3.3 |
| Prescription writing and dispensing | Parts of a prescription, abbreviations, posology, dosage forms | 3.4 |

Standard books: Mandal and Mandal, *A Textbook of Homoeopathic Pharmacy*; *Homoeopathic Pharmacopoeia of India* (HPI); Hahnemann's *Organon* (§§264 to 271 for preparation); the Drugs and Cosmetics Act 1940 and Rules 1945.

**Memory hook:** pharmacy is a kitchen: **ingredients** (sources), **pots and water** (vehicles), **the recipe** (scales and potentisation), **the food inspector** (HPI and the Act) and **the menu card** (the prescription).

## 3.1 Sources, vehicles and drug collection

### Sources of drugs

| Kingdom | What is used | Examples |
|---|---|---|
| Vegetable | Whole plant or a part: root, bark, leaf, flower, seed, resin, juice | Aconite, Belladonna, Cinchona (bark), Nux vomica (seeds) |
| Mineral | Elements, salts, acids | Sulphur, Natrum mur, Calcarea carb, Nitric acid |

| Kingdom | What is used | Examples |
|---|---|---|
| Animal | Whole animal, venom or secretion | Apis (bee), Cantharis (beetle), Lachesis (snake venom), Sepia (ink) |
| Nosodes | Diseased tissue or products of disease | Psorinum, Medorrhinum, Tuberculinum |
| Sarcodes | Healthy animal tissue or secretion | Thyroidinum, Adrenalinum, Pepsinum |
| Imponderabilia | Energy with no matter | X-ray, Magnetis poli, Sol, Luna |

## Collecting plants

- Collect from the plant's **natural habitat**, wild where possible, healthy and free from disease.
- Collect in **dry, clear weather**, and use the plant fresh unless the monograph says dried.
- Collect each part when it is most active: **whole plants** usually as flowering begins; **seeds and fruits** when fully ripe.
- Identify the plant correctly by botanical name; the HPI monograph gives the part used and how to prepare it.

## Vehicles

A **vehicle** is the inert medium that carries the drug. It must be pure, inert, and keep the drug stable.

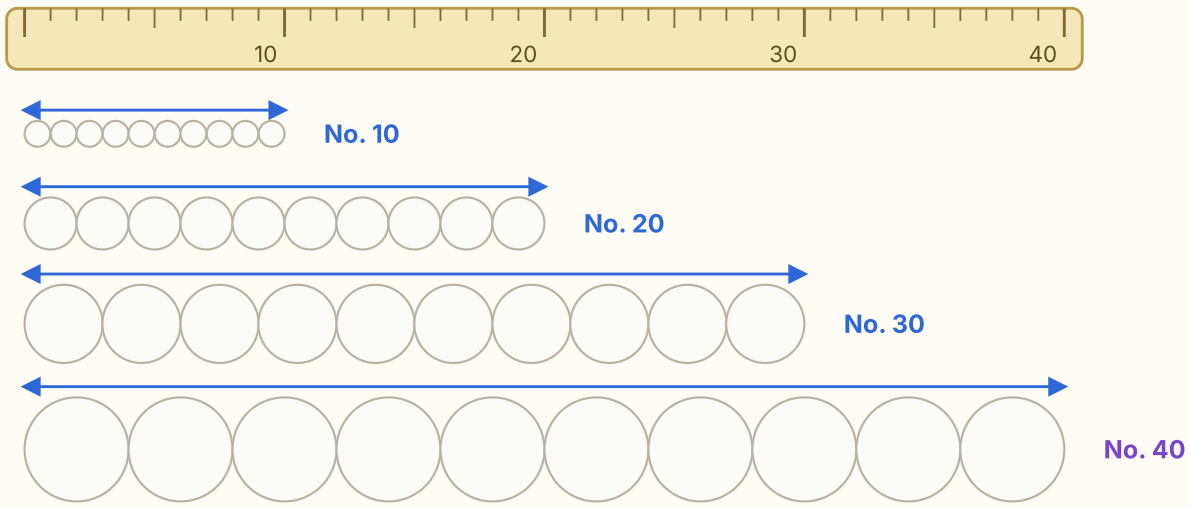
| Vehicle | Key facts |
|---|---|
| Purified water | Used to dissolve water-soluble substances and to make some lower dilutions |
| Strong alcohol | 95% v/v ethanol (limits about 94.7 to 95.2%); the usual base for dilutions |
| Absolute alcohol | At least 99.4% v/v |
| Dilute alcohol | Strong alcohol diluted with purified water; used for some mother tinctures |
| Dispensing alcohol | 88% v/v; used to medicate globules |
| Glycerin | For glycerols and some external preparations |
| Sugar of milk (lactose) | Solid vehicle for triturations and tablets; about 1 g dissolves in 5 ml of cold water; insoluble in alcohol |
| Cane sugar globules | Sizes 5 to 80 (commonly 10 to 40); sizes 40 to 80 are called pilules; the size number is the length in mm of 10 globules in a row |
| Tablets | Lactose, about 1 grain (65 mg) each |

| Vehicle | Key facts |
|---|---|
| Cones | Cane sugar and egg; a No. 6 cone absorbs one drop of dispensing alcohol |

## Globule sizes: read the number

Cane-sugar globules on a millimetre ruler

**The size number = the length, in mm, of 10 globules laid in a row**




Sizes run 5 to 80 (commonly 10 to 40); 40 to 80 are called pilules.
Globules are cane sugar; they are medicated with 88% dispensing alcohol, then dried.
LM potencies use tiny poppy-seed globules: one drop medicates 500 of them.

Globule sizes · the number is the length in mm of 10 globules in a row

**Memory hook: 95, 99.4, 88**: "Strong is **95**, absolute **99.4**, the dispenser is **88**." Lactose dissolves in **water**, never in alcohol: so a 3C trituration is dissolved in water first, and alcohol is added after.

## Preparing the neutral vehicles

A vehicle is **neutral**: medicinally inert, free from taste and smell, chemically stable, and able to carry the drug energy. Every vehicle is prepared and stored so that it stays pure.

| Vehicle | How it is prepared and kept |
|---|---|
| Distilled water | Made by distillation; used fresh to dissolve triturations (the 3C conversion) and to make dilute alcohols; stored in clean, glass-stoppered bottles |
| Alcohol | Strong alcohol (95% v/v) is diluted with distilled water to the strength each step needs, for example dispensing alcohol (88%) for medicating globules |

| Vehicle | How it is prepared and kept |
|---|---|
| Sugar of milk | Pure, crystalline lactose, free from cane sugar and starch; ground to a fine powder and sieved before trituration; kept dry in closed containers |
| Globules, pilules, tablets | Globules and pilules are made of cane sugar; tablets are pressed from lactose; all are medicated only after they are made, by soaking in the potency in 88% alcohol and drying |

**Memory hook:** water dissolves, alcohol preserves, lactose grinds, sugar carries. Neutral means it adds nothing of its own.

## 3.2 Scales and potentisation

**Potentisation** (dynamisation) is the step-by-step dilution of a drug with **succussion** (vigorous shaking) for liquids or **trituration** (grinding) for solids. Hahnemann describes it in Organon §§269 to 271; §270 gives the LM method.

### The three scales

| Scale | Ratio per step | Symbol | Introduced by | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Decimal | 1 : 10 | X or D | Constantine Hering | Mainly for low potencies and triturations |
| Centesimal | 1 : 100 | C or CH | Hahnemann | The standard scale; 1C = 2X in dilution |
| Fifty millesimal (LM, Q) | 1 : 50,000 | LM, 0/1, Q | Hahnemann, 6th edition | 100 succussions per step; written 0/1, 0/2 and so on |

### Ten, hundred, fifty thousand: the three potency scales

Drug to vehicle at each step, who introduced it, and how it is written

**Decimal · X**

**1 : 10**

1 part drug + 9 parts vehicle
introduced by Hering
written 6X, 12X

**Centesimal · C**

**1 : 100**

1 part drug + 99 parts vehicle
Hahnemann's standard scale
written 30C, 200C, 1M

**Fifty millesimal · LM**

**1 : 50,000**

100 succussions per step
Organon 6th edition, §270
written 0/1, 0/2, 0/3

### Insoluble drugs: three triturations, then conversion to liquid

**Drug + lactose** ground → **1C** one hour → **2C** one hour → **3C** one hour → **Dissolve** water first → **4C onwards** in alcohol

potency scales and trituration · 3 scales, 6 steps

Say the big numbers aloud, left to right: ten, hundred, fifty thousand. Then walk the bottom row: three hours of grinding before the drug ever meets alcohol.

The **mother tincture** (Ø) is the starting liquid preparation of a drug. **12C (24X)** is roughly where Avogadro's number is passed, so no molecule of the original substance is likely to remain.

## Methods of making liquid potencies

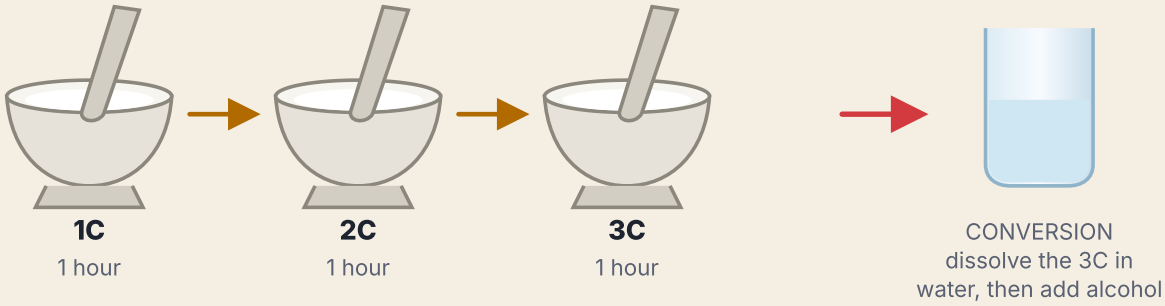
| Method | How | Key point |
|---|---|---|
| **Hahnemannian (multi-vial)** | A fresh vial for every potency | The official method; most accurate |
| **Korsakovian (single-vial)** | The same vial is emptied and refilled for each step | Faster, less exact; marked K |
| **Continuous fluxion** | Fluid flows through a chamber with no separate steps | Used for very high potencies by machine |

## From drug to potency

Trituration for solids, succussion for liquids

**Solids: TRITURATION with sugar of milk**

for insoluble drugs: metals, most minerals, many animal products




each hour = 3 rounds of 20 minutes: grind, then scrape

**Liquids: DILUTION + SUCCUSSION (vigorous shaking)**

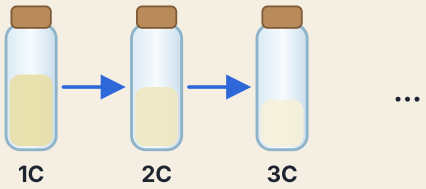
centesimal step: 1 part of the previous potency + 99 parts of alcohol, then succussed



succuss

**HAHNEMANNIAN (multi-vial)**

a fresh vial for every potency · official, most accurate




**KORSAKOVIAN (single-vial)**

the same vial is emptied and refilled each step · faster, marked K



empty → refill → succuss → repeat

Ratio per step: X 1 : 10 (Hering) · C 1 : 100 (Hahnemann) · LM 1 : 50,000 (6th edition, 100 succussions).

From drug to potency · trituration for solids, succussion for liquids

### Trituration

- Used for **insoluble** drugs (metals, most minerals, many animal products): the drug is ground with **sugar of milk**.
- Each potency takes **one hour**: three rounds of 20 minutes, each of grinding and scraping.
- Insoluble drugs are triturated to the 3C (6X); then the 3C is dissolved in water, alcohol is added, and the potency goes on as a liquid (**conversion**).

### How LM potency is made (Organon §270)

1. Triturate the drug to the **3C**.
2. Dissolve 1 grain of the 3C in 500 drops of a water and alcohol mixture.
3. Take 1 drop of this, add 100 drops of alcohol and give **100 succussions**: this medicates poppy-seed-sized globules, **500 globules per drop**. That is LM 1 (0/1).
4. Dissolve 1 such globule in a drop of water, add 100 drops of alcohol, succuss 100 times: LM 2. And so on.

The ratio is 1/100 × 1/500 = **1 : 50,000** per step.

**Memory hook:** "**Ten, hundred, fifty thousand**": X is 10, C is 100, LM is 50,000. **Hering** brought the **X**; **Hahnemann** made **C** and **LM**. One **hour** per trituration, **three** triturations, then **convert**.

## 3.3 Standards and legislation

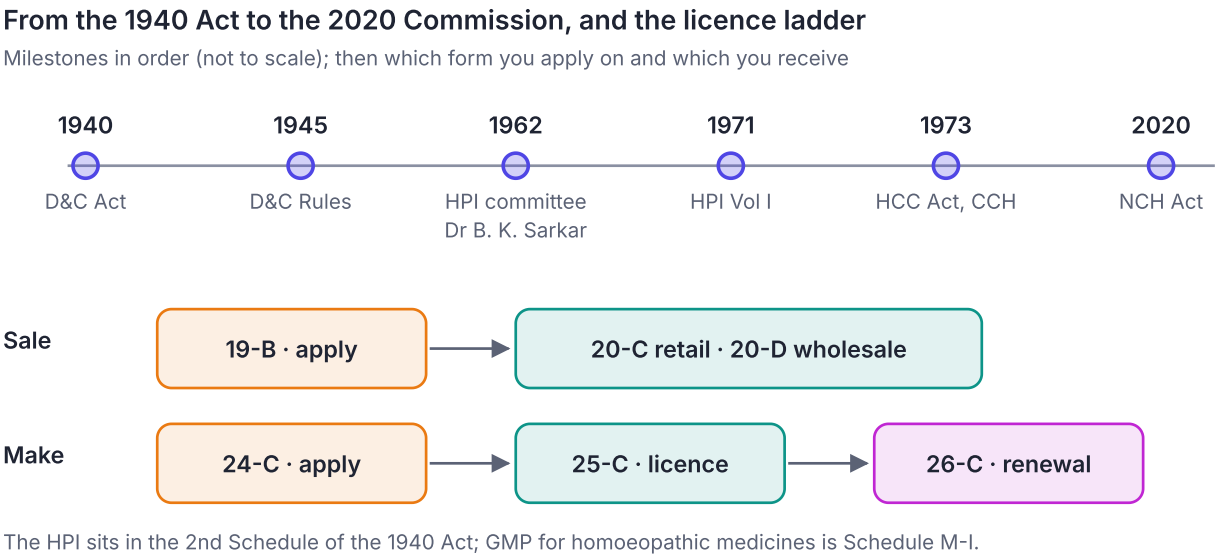
### Homoeopathic Pharmacopoeia of India (HPI)

- A **pharmacopoeia** is the official book of standards for drugs: identity, purity, strength and method of preparation.
- The Government of India set up the **Homoeopathic Pharmacopoeia Committee in 1962**, under **Dr B. K. Sarkar**.
- **HPI Volume I** was published in **1971**; further volumes followed. Before it, Indian manufacturers followed the **HPUS** (USA) and the German pharmacopoeia.
- The HPI is listed in the **Second Schedule of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940**, which makes its standards legally binding.
- Most HPI mother tinctures are made by the **new method**, at a drug strength of about **1/10**; Hahnemann's older method sorted drugs into classes by their juice content.
- Drugs are tested at the **Pharmacopoeia Commission for Indian Medicine and Homoeopathy (PCIM&H), Ghaziabad**, which took over the Homoeopathic Pharmacopoeia Laboratory.

### Drugs and Cosmetics Act 1940 and Rules 1945

| Provision | What it covers |
|---|---|
| Rule 2(dd) | Defines homoeopathic medicines (the parenteral route is excluded) |
| Rule 30AA | Import of new homoeopathic medicines |
| Rules 67A, 67D, 67E, 67GG | Sale of homoeopathic medicines and the sale licence |

| Provision | What it covers |
|---|---|
| Form 19-B | Application for a licence to sell |
| Form 20-C / 20-D | Retail / wholesale sale licence (valid 5 years) |
| Form 24-C | Application for a licence to manufacture |
| Form 25-C | Licence to manufacture |
| Form 26-C | Certificate of renewal |
| Schedule M-I | Good manufacturing practice for homoeopathic medicines |




pharmacy law timeline and licence forms

Orange boxes are what you apply on, green what you receive; renewal comes last.

## Related councils

- **Central Council of Homoeopathy** (CCH) was set up under the **Homoeopathy Central Council Act, 1973**, to regulate education and practice.
- It was replaced by the **National Commission for Homoeopathy** (NCH) under the **NCH Act, 2020**.

**Memory hook:** "**62** formed, **71** printed": committee 1962, HPI Vol I 1971. Licence forms run like a ladder: **19-B** you ask to sell, **20-C/D** you sell, **24-C** you ask to make, **25-C** you make, **26-C** you renew.

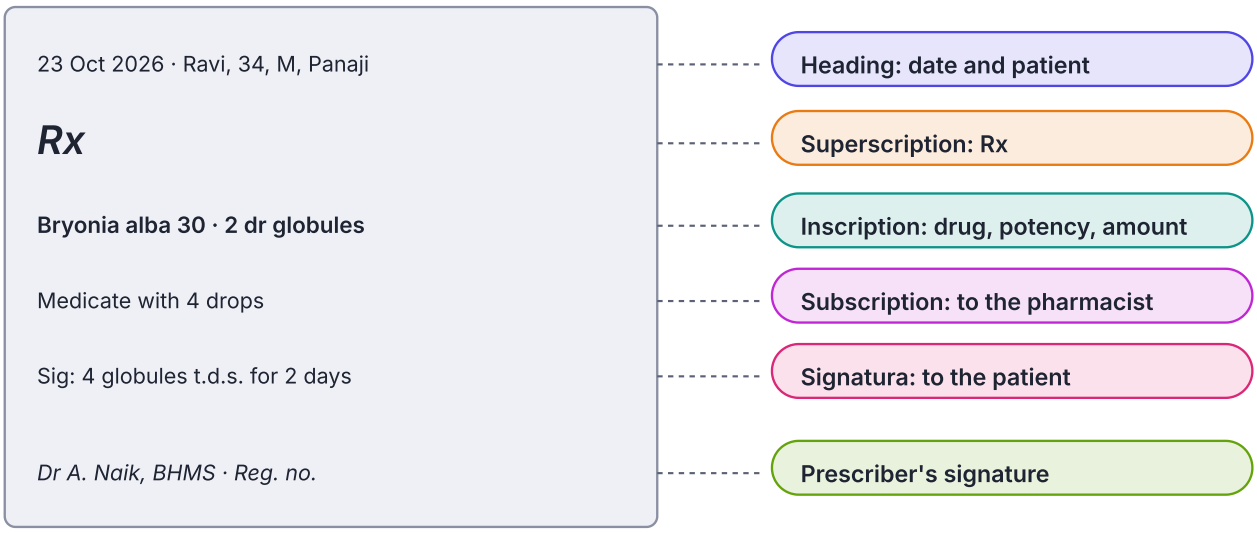
## 3.4 Prescription writing and dispensing

### Parts of a prescription

1. **Heading:** date; the patient's name, age, sex and address; the prescriber's name, qualification and registration number.
2. **Superscription:** the symbol **Rx** ("take thou").
3. **Inscription:** the medicine, its potency and quantity, for example *Bryonia alba 30, 2 dram globules*.
4. **Subscription:** directions to the pharmacist (how to prepare or medicate).
5. **Signatura (signature):** directions to the patient, often marked **Sig.** or **S.**
6. **The prescriber's signature.**

**A prescription reads top to bottom like a letter**

An example slip on the left; the name of each part on the right




anatomy of a prescription · 6 parts

The two that get mixed up: **sub**scription is for the pharmacist, **sig**natura is for the patient.

### Rules

- Write clearly and in full; one remedy at a time, as the Organon teaches (§273).
- Always state the **potency**, the **scale** and the **dose form**.
- Name the medicine by its full Latin name, not a vague abbreviation.
- Give the patient plain directions: when, how many, how long, and what to avoid (strong smells such as camphor or coffee, if the prescriber wishes).

### Abbreviations

| Abbreviation | Meaning |
|---|---|
| o.d. / b.d. / t.d.s. / q.i.d. | Once / twice / three times / four times a day |
| h.s. | At bedtime |
| s.o.s. | If needed |
| stat. | At once |
| a.c. / p.c. | Before food / after food |
| aq. | Water |
| gtt. | Drops |
| glob. | Globules |
| q.s. | Quantity sufficient |
| Ø | Mother tincture |
| S.L. | Saccharum lactis (sugar of milk, placebo) |

## Dosage forms

- **Internal:** mother tincture, dilutions, triturations, medicated globules (pilules), tablets, cones.
- **External:** ointments, lotions, glycerols, oils, liniments.
- **Medicating globules:** pour enough of the potency, made in **dispensing alcohol (88%)**, to soak all the globules in a clean vial; shake, then let them dry.
- **Storage:** amber glass, well corked, cool and dark, away from strong odours and direct sunlight.

## Posology

- Posology is the science of dose: the potency, the quantity and the repetition.
- The **minimum dose** (Organon §§275 to 279) is the smallest dose that cures gently.
- Acute cases may need frequent repetition; chronic cases wait for the dose to act (see Topic 1, 1.3).

**Memory hook:** a prescription reads like a letter: **date and address**, "**Dear pharmacist**" (Rx), **what to send** (inscription), **how to pack it** (subscription), **how to use it** (signatura), **signed** by you.

## Rapid revision

| Cue | Fact |
|---|---|
| Strong alcohol | 95% v/v |
| Absolute alcohol | At least 99.4% v/v |
| Dispensing alcohol | 88% v/v; medicates globules |
| Sugar of milk | Lactose; soluble in water, insoluble in alcohol |
| Globule size | Length in mm of 10 globules in a row; 40 to 80 are pilules |
| Decimal scale | 1:10, X; introduced by Hering |
| Centesimal scale | 1:100, C; Hahnemann |
| LM scale | 1:50,000; 100 succussions; Organon §270 |
| Avogadro limit | About 12C (24X) |
| Trituration | Insoluble drugs with sugar of milk; one hour per potency; to 3C then converted |
| Hahnemannian method | Separate vial for each potency |
| Korsakovian method | One vial emptied and refilled |
| HPI | Committee 1962 (Dr B. K. Sarkar); Vol I 1971; in 2nd Schedule of the D&C Act |
| Testing laboratory | PCIM&H, Ghaziabad |
| Sale licence | Form 20-C retail, 20-D wholesale; applied for on 19-B |
| Manufacture licence | Form 25-C; applied for on 24-C |
| GMP | Schedule M-I |
| Superscription | Rx |
| Signatura | Directions to the patient |
| S.L. | Sugar of milk placebo |

## One-glance recall card

### Topic 3 recall card: the 15 numbers asked most

Cover the small lines, say the fact from the big cue, then check

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **95%**<br>strong alcohol (v/v);<br>absolute is at least 99.4% | **88%**<br>dispensing alcohol:<br>medicates globules | **Lactose**<br>dissolves in water,<br>not in alcohol |
| **1 : 10**<br>decimal scale, X;<br>introduced by Hering | **1 : 100**<br>centesimal scale, C;<br>Hahnemann's standard | **1 : 50,000**<br>LM scale, Organon §270;<br>100 succussions a step |
| **12C = 24X**<br>Avogadro's number passed;<br>no molecule likely left | **3C, 1 hour each**<br>triturate insolubles to 3C,<br>then dissolve in water | **Multi vs single**<br>Hahnemannian: new vial;<br>Korsakovian: same vial |
| **1962 · 1971**<br>HPI committee (B. K. Sarkar);<br>HPI Vol I published | **2nd Schedule**<br>HPI is in the 2nd Schedule<br>of the D&C Act 1940 | **19-B → 20-C/D**<br>apply to sell, then retail<br>or wholesale licence |
| **24-C → 25-C**<br>apply to make, then the<br>manufacture licence | **Schedule M-I**<br>good manufacturing practice<br>for homoeopathic medicines | **Sub vs Sig**<br>subscription: pharmacist;<br>signatura: patient |

Topic 3 recall card · 15 tiles

For the last ten minutes before the exam: cover the small lines of each tile and say the fact from the big cue.

## Practice MCQs

1. Strong alcohol as defined in the HPI contains about: (a) 88% v/v (b) 95% v/v (c) 99.4% v/v (d) 62% v/v
2. Dispensing alcohol used to medicate globules is: (a) 95% (b) 70% (c) 88% (d) 60%
3. Absolute alcohol contains not less than: (a) 95% (b) 98% (c) 99.4% (d) 100%
4. The drug-to-vehicle ratio of the decimal scale is: (a) 1:10 (b) 1:100 (c) 1:1000 (d) 1:50,000
5. The decimal scale was introduced by: (a) Hahnemann (b) Hering (c) Korsakoff (d) Kent
6. The 50 millesimal potency is described in the Organon in: (a) §128 (b) §153 (c) §270 (d) §273
7. Each LM potency step receives: (a) 10 successions (b) 50 successions (c) 100 successions (d) 2 successions
8. Insoluble substances are triturated up to: (a) 1C (b) 3C (c) 6C (d) 12C
9. Each trituration potency takes about: (a) 10 minutes (b) 30 minutes (c) one hour (d) three hours

10. The single-vial method of potentisation is the: (a) Hahnemannian (b) Korsakovian (c) fluxion (d) LM
11. Sugar of milk is: (a) soluble in alcohol (b) insoluble in water (c) soluble in water, insoluble in alcohol (d) insoluble in both
12. The Homoeopathic Pharmacopoeia Committee was formed in: (a) 1948 (b) 1962 (c) 1971 (d) 1973
13. HPI Volume I was published in: (a) 1962 (b) 1971 (c) 1973 (d) 1980
14. A retail sale licence for homoeopathic medicines is issued in Form: (a) 19-B (b) 20-C (c) 20-D (d) 25-C
15. A licence to manufacture homoeopathic medicines is issued in Form: (a) 24-C (b) 25-C (c) 26-C (d) 20-D
16. Good manufacturing practice for homoeopathic medicines is laid down in: (a) Schedule M (b) Schedule M-I (c) Schedule H (d) Schedule X
17. The part of a prescription giving directions to the patient is the: (a) superscription (b) inscription (c) subscription (d) signatura
18. In homoeopathic prescriptions, S.L. stands for: (a) sublingual (b) saccharum lactis (c) single liquid (d) solution
19. Globules of size 40 to 80 are called: (a) cones (b) pilules (c) tablets (d) granules
20. The potency beyond which no molecule of the original drug is likely to remain is about: (a) 3C (b) 6C (c) 12C (d) 30C

## Answer key

| Q | Answer | Why |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | b | 95% v/v ethanol |
| 2 | c | 88% v/v |
| 3 | c | At least 99.4% v/v |
| 4 | a | X = 1:10 |
| 5 | b | Constantine Hering |
| 6 | c | §270, the LM method |
| 7 | c | 100 succussions per step |
| 8 | b | Triturate to 3C, then convert |
| 9 | c | Three rounds of 20 minutes |
| 10 | b | Korsakovian: one vial |

| Q | Answer | Why |
|---|---|---|
| 11 | c | Lactose: water yes, alcohol no |
| 12 | b | 1962, under Dr B. K. Sarkar |
| 13 | b | 1971 |
| 14 | b | 20-C retail; 20-D wholesale |
| 15 | b | 25-C; 24-C is the application |
| 16 | b | Schedule M-I |
| 17 | d | Signatura: directions to the patient |
| 18 | b | Sugar of milk, the placebo |
| 19 | b | Pilules |
| 20 | c | 12C (24X): Avogadro's number passed |